tandem to constantly oppose, the prime minister, who is usually one to befittingly respond to critics with retaliations as sharp as a *kukri* knife, instead prioritized leading the country out of the devastating wave of infections. Possibly, this is the kind of wisdom which can be brought on only by decades of public service—choosing one's battles.

Barring some official objections raised by the Indian missions in the countries where these pieces were published, the GoI's machinery and the BJP's media cell failed to offer a sophisticated counter. In fact, some efforts to counter were counterproductive, i.e., a piece written and published by a party functionary in an Indian e-media outlet called *The Daily Guardian* titled in bold, capital letters, 'The prime minister has been "working hard", don't get trapped by the "opposition's barbs".' This article was retweeted by multiple high-level functionaries of the party, starting with the head of the media cell Amit Malviya, followed by several ministers in the Union Cabinet.[30] Somehow, they didn't quite understand that media powerhouses like *The Washington Post* or *The Guardian* cannot be countered by a small, irrelevant Indian news portal which doesn't even have physical newspapers in circulation. Similarly, when *The Lancet* posted an editorial which held the administration fully responsible for India's COVID-19 emergency,[31] the then Union Health Minister Dr Harsh Vardhan, in response, shared a post from a blog named 'Pankaj Chaturvedi's Thoughts' with a note 'A fair rebuttal to the imbalanced editorial in *The Lancet* titled "India's COVID19 emergency" published on May 8th. While the COVID crisis did assume alarming proportions in India, it was indeed important to remain politically unbiased for a reputed journal.'[32] It was also shocking to see the former Union health minister responding to a giant in the world of scientific writing with a private individual's blog post which had an image of a cat as its thumbnail. It portrayed a lack of sophistication in responding to the international media community and understanding its nuances. The former health minister also engaged in several ill-timed activities which became opportune moments for the media to lambast him. For instance: when he graced along with Union Minister Nitin Gadkari, the launch of an Ayurvedic company's drug touted to be a cure for COVID-19.[33] While Ayurveda, India's ancient medicine system, has a slew of products and concoctions which are proven to be immunity boosting, so much so that after the advent of the pandemic, turmeric-ginger cold-pressed shots became a rage, quickly flying off the grocery store shelves worldwide, the